MONTHLY UPDATE

Africa: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-12 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.*

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION · SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE · COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION · CAPACITY AND INCLUSION · FINANCE

Summary of the month

The AfCFTA's digital-trade layer moved from instrument to build, with a joint venture signed to construct a Digital Trade Corridor and Somalia set to become the 50th ratifying state, while its digital-trade protocol annexes remain unratified two years after adoption. PAPSS opened a second strategic plan on 4 September aimed at every African country within five years, reporting 30 countries connected and transaction volume up more than 1,000% since 2022 without publishing the volume itself, and stablecoin settlement rails drew their first coordinated regulatory attention from three national supervisors and an exploration by PAPSS itself.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

The AfCFTA's digital layer moved on two fronts. The Secretariat and a Ghanaian technology company signed a joint venture in Accra on 31 August to build a Digital Trade Corridor facilitating, tracking and settling cross-border trade transactions without routing payments through third countries — a signed agreement rather than a system in service, with no build timetable, cost or governance arrangement stated.

AFRINIC's governance dispute deepened on every front at once. Both the January and March 2026 meetings established quorum with AFRINIC's community seats still empty, so a valid global decision and an unrepresented region are simultaneously true, and the review's finding that outreach was sufficient does not speak to regional participation.

Three smaller developments: the Digital Parliaments Project Africa launched at the Parliament of Ghana on 6 August, a cohort of Ghana, Botswana, South Africa, Gambia, Senegal and the Pan-African Parliament with no funder, amount or work programme stated; the eighth Korea-Africa Economic Cooperation ministerial adopted a Joint Declaration and an Action Plan for 2027-2028 in Seoul on 9 September, with 45 African countries represented, committing both sides to modular data centres, AI models reflecting African languages and further funding for electricity and telecommunications gaps; and the 15th Africa Internet Governance Forum is scheduled for Accra, 2-5 November, an event schedule rather than an outcome, with no agenda, host-government commitment or funding yet published.

African states went into the last round of preparation for the ITU's November conference in Doha. The African Telecommunications Union's fourth and final preparatory meeting opened in Abidjan on 15 September, to adopt common African proposals and candidatures for elected posts by 17 September; the adopted report is not yet held.

COMESA put a draft baseline study of AI across its member states to a validation meeting at Mbabane on 16 to 18 September, the first phase towards a regional AI strategy and model regulatory framework. No date is set for either. The continental disease-control agency's head of digital health says the health data governance initiative started in 2025 with more than 40 member states, and that the framework will guide who may access health data, for what purpose and for how long. The continental health agency posted the outcome statement of its primary health care coordination mechanism, endorsed in June 2026 with a digital health forum for interoperability and data governance.

Instruments and harmonisation

Data protection

The continent's data protection authorities marked a date rather than a rule: the Fifth Board of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities signed a declaration on 3 September proclaiming 21 September as Africa Data Protection Day, executing a decision of the network's ninth annual general meeting in May 2026 - an account written by the data protection director of one member authority on a professional network, with the declaration text itself not held.

Standards

AFRINIC's own instruments moved on two separate tracks from its governance dispute above. A second policy track opened on address exhaustion from the other end. Draft 2 of AFPUB-2026-v6-001 would make any IPv4 request conditional on holding or simultaneously requesting IPv6 space, on a deployment plan showing the network's top-25 IPv4 traffic destinations, and on reaching 25% IPv6 within twelve months, 50% within twenty-four and 75% within forty-eight - 25%, 75% and 95% for content-hosting networks - and the registry's own impact assessment concedes that neither the evidence standard nor the top-25 measurement method is defined. AFRINIC 37 reached no consensus and the proposal returned to the mailing list, the unresolved question being whether the thresholds measure the operator's own work or adoption controlled by its customers and by external networks. A census of the registry's data went the other way: a frozen copy of the official public WHOIS dump held 28,206 maintainer objects, of which 1,345 still carried a deprecated MD5-PW or CRYPT-PW method tag and 1,285 carried nothing else - stored labels rather than credentials or proven vulnerabilities, and the registry publishes no operation-specific account of whether the deployed update service would honour, reject or migrate them.

The ITU reported on 23 September that its digital financial services security recommendations have been adopted by the southern and eastern African regulator associations, are under consideration by the central African one and are at draft stage with the west African one. No adoption date is given for any of them. The registry's Board ratified the recovered-IPv4 soft-landing and quarantine policy on 25 September 2026, listed as awaiting implementation. The registry's Board ratified the documented-exception route around the 90% utilisation threshold on 25 September 2026.

A second draft of the registry's policy-process guidelines would let the working group petition to ratify policy when no operative Board exists; the route depends on a change to the Bylaws.

AI

The scarcity behind African-language models is being attacked at the data layer. A research company has set out to build training data for a thousand African languages, after years in which the absence of that data was what stopped anyone building language technology for the continent. It is an ambition rather than a delivered corpus: no language list, licence, funding or release is held, and it sits alongside the grant programme covering twenty-six language-model projects recorded separately.

The Commission's Infrastructure and Energy Department put draft AU Guidelines on AI Governance and Regulation to an online open consultation on 23 and 24 September, with written submissions accepted to 30 September; the draft itself is not published.

A Hub for AI and Disability Inclusion, hosted at KNUST, and an African Disability Data Network were launched in Nairobi with IDRC, UK and AI4D backing, to build datasets including African sign languages and assess disability inclusion in national AI strategies; no dataset is yet published.

The 2026 Global Index on Responsible AI, presented at a regional AI governance dialogue convened by the Global Center on AI Governance, finds African countries scoring high on skilling and capacity-building and low on labour protections, with African workers concentrated in the low-paid and precarious parts of the AI value chain; no country scores are held. The World Bank's regional economic update urged Sub-Saharan governments to invest in AI, pointing to low-cost applications, shared data centres and stronger data-protection laws.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

Last-mile broadband is moving to radio. By May 2026 40 operators had launched 5G fixed wireless access across 37 African markets, where trenching and permits make fibre to the door slow to pay back.

Data Storage

The capacity the announcements are measured against is small. The data centres association counts about 360MW active, 238MW under construction and 656MW in the pipeline in 2026, against a consultancy estimate of demand rising from about 0.4GW to 1.5-2.2GW by 2030.

Energy

A philanthropic accelerator announced on 24 September demonstrations testing whether computing load placed at mini-grids can serve as an anchor customer and improve their economics: five new solar-plus-storage sites in Kenya, an under-used solar plant in DR Congo and three rural sites in Sierra Leone, serving about 85,000 people in all, with community demand given priority over compute. No budget, compute buyer or start date is stated.

Cybersecurity

An account of a continental cyberthreat assessment, published on 2 September, records deepfake incidents up sevenfold between the second and fourth quarters of 2024, 94% of agencies lacking digital forensics tools and only 8% of intelligence analysts with advanced AI expertise.

Data Exchange

Delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia, with African Union representatives, completed a two-week learning mission to India on 7 September 2026 under UNDP's Africa Accelerator for Digital Public Infrastructure, examining digital identity, payment and data exchange systems.

Digital Payments and Fintech

PAPSS closed its first strategic plan and opened a second on 4 September, moving from building spread to deepening use: 30 countries, about 26 central banks and more than 200 financial institutions are connected, with about 38 countries and 80% continental coverage targeted by the end of 2026 and every African country within five years, and phase two is to be built around remittances, merchant payments and a single interface onto connected accounts. The operator says transaction volume has grown more than 1,000% and transaction value 125% since 2022, that

payments now settle in an average of seven seconds against an original 120-second design target, and that an artificial-intelligence layer screens for suspicious activity and liens before value is released — but declines to publish the volume and value those percentages are measured from before a report due early 2027, and the same week's briefings put the connected central banks at 24 in one account and 26 in another against the network's own June coverage list of 190 institutions across 28 countries, which also records member states with no live bank or wallet at all. South Africa is named as the only large African market still outside. The obstacles named are not technical: low awareness, national policies mandating settlement in particular currencies, and regional switches' fear of being cannibalised, answered with the formula that a country may keep its own system and connect it in.

The continental operator has now joined that question rather than only observing it: PAPSS's chief executive disclosed on 5 September that the system is exploring support for stablecoins and other digital currencies inside the payments system, naming Nigerian securities and central-bank regulation as the approach he endorsed and saying announcements could follow - a statement of intent with no design, timetable or approval attached. Separately, a cross-border payments startup launched direct yuan payouts into Chinese bank accounts on 1 September, alongside broader continental take-up of China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System — known from a single newspaper account, with no operator or central-bank statement of African participation held.

Elsewhere: Standard Bank extended online UnionPay acceptance to nearly 900 merchants across nine markets against a stated 7 million UnionPay cards issued continent-wide; MTN Group's half-year results to 30 June recorded 13.0 billion transactions carrying US$330.5bn, up 17.2% in volume, on 70.8 million monthly active mobile-money users; AfricaNenda's deputy chief executive put the cost of sending money within Africa at 8.78% of the amount sent, against an SDG target of 3%, in an interview rather than a published series — a figure for movement *within* Africa, which is not the one the published series measures: the World Bank's Remittance Prices Worldwide put the cost of sending US$200 into Sub-Saharan Africa at 8.46% in the third quarter of 2025, against a global average of 6.36% and the United Nations target of 3%, with banks close to 15% and much of the cost carried in exchange-rate spreads rather than disclosed fees; a research firm's policy brief put unmet trade finance demand at US$74bn-US$100bn, with commercial banks intermediating about 23% of continental trade against 40% over 2011-2019; and instant-payment interoperability was described as meeting a regulatory wall of divergent national rules.

A commercial rail widened alongside the public ones. A stablecoin payments platform partnered a local payout provider to extend stablecoin payouts across African markets, settling into local currency through the partner's rails. No country list, volume, licence or central bank position is stated.

The continental rail reported growth without a base: volumes up about 1,000% and values up about 120% year on year, with 24 central banks connected, figures that carry no absolute totals.

Two card-network products launched on 22 September. Mastercard launched Wallet Pay, a set of wallet interoperability, card-issuing, acceptance and cross-border services for digital wallet providers, with MTN Group Fintech and AXIAN among its African launch partners, and Verto and Visa launched a corporate card for African businesses that settles in 11 currencies from linked wallets. Neither publishes African volumes or pricing.

A mobile-money operator moved toward public markets: Airtel Money, running in 13 African markets, announced on 23 September its intention to float in London, with existing shareholders selling, no new capital raised and the IFC to buy up to GBP67.2m of shares; the prospectus is due in early October.

Mastercard said it will explore pairing its account-to-account fraud-scoring and dispute service with the Mojaloop Foundation's open-source instant-payment software, and work with AfricaNenda on instant-payment policy and governance, in an announcement reported on 30 September; no country deployment, sum or timetable is stated. The continental commission's payments framework was presented in Nairobi with three preconditions, among them a

binding legal instrument and a US$120m fund. A bank operating in 34 African countries said on 9 October 2026 that it would sign an agreement in China the next day to join the Cross-Border Interbank Payment System for yuan transactions, and is in talks to offer yuan settlement jointly with a Chinese bank.

Conditional trading in Airtel Money began on the London Stock Exchange on 9 October 2026 after an oversubscribed offer in which existing shareholders sold 270 million shares at GBP1.96, raising about US$703 million; the shares touched GBP2.00 before trading at GBP1.93, with unconditional dealings due on 14 October.

Sectoral management information systems

WHO launched a Regional Health Data Hub from Addis Ababa on 27 August, integrating fragmented health data across all 47 member states of the region, bringing together maternal, newborn, child and adolescent health and noncommunicable disease data; the platform carries 53 datasets and 7,965 indicators, about 65% of them ingested against a target of 80% by the end of 2026, and its governance framework is still in development — the organisation's own figures, with no independent measure of coverage held.

The seam these platforms are meant to close is the one a live outbreak found again. The African Society for Laboratory Medicine's own multi-country assessment, completed before the Democratic Republic of Congo's current Ebola outbreak, covered 26 countries — every one with a functioning surveillance system and core diagnostic capacity, nearly nine in ten with a laboratory coordination unit, and 3,964 laboratories mapped across fourteen, and named digital interoperability between laboratories and surveillance platforms, alongside specimen referral, workforce surge and domestic financing, as the weak points; the response has had to improvise at exactly those seams. It is a reference study written up by its own author rather than a dated development, and is carried here as the measure a data hub would have to move.

The WHO regional office launched a three-year initiative to digitise the planning, delivery and monitoring of health campaigns, starting with seven pilot countries, on an open platform built with the eGov Foundation.

Coordination and collaboration

Innovation ecosystem

The African Telecommunications Union opened the fifth edition of its Africa Innovation Challenge on 17 September 2026 with a US$60,000 prize pool, with a stated focus on AI-based software.

China activities

Ten African states, Algeria, Cameroon, Ethiopia, Kenya and South Africa among them, are among the 29 founding members of the World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organisation, in an announcement that also carries 5,000 AI training places for developing countries over five years and agreements with Cote d'Ivoire, Guinea and Cameroon to extend a weather-warning system, on a Chinese state account of 1 September.

India activities

Five African delegations completed a two-week mission to India under UNDP's digital public infrastructure accelerator, concluded on 7 September 2026; no cooperation instrument, financing or adoption commitment is published as an outcome.

Capacity and inclusion

Training and skills

The month's other capacity item is about who runs the state rather than who uses the technology. A continental capacity foundation convened alumni of its public-sector leadership programme, run with private-foundation support, and argued that reform stalls on leadership gaps, institutional fragmentation and resistance to change rather than on policy — its executive secretary putting it that public sector reform is rarely held back by a lack of good ideas. No cohort size, cost, country list or evaluation is published.

The Her CyberTracks programme gathered nearly 50 women cybersecurity professionals in Addis Ababa for its 2026 regional training, co-implemented by the ITU and GIZ with European funding.

On 24 September the continental development bank, a UN-led AI hub, Google and Apolitical launched free, self-paced AI courses for serving public officials, developed by Stanford University Online and SDA Bocconi. No enrolment target, budget or duration is stated. The European-funded regulatory capacity programme convened its eighth cohort at Nairobi from 5 to 9 October, six national regulators with three regional regulators' associations.

Digital divides

The mobile industry association's own figure is higher still: an entry-level internet-enabled handset cost the poorest fifth in Sub-Saharan Africa 76% of average monthly income at the end of 2025, against 44% across low- and middle-income countries, and memory prices more than doubled between the third quarter of 2025 and the first of 2026.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The Seoul ministerial closed on 11 September with two AfDB-Korea agreements and a structure for an AI hub; no sum is attached. The development bank also signed letters of intent with KAIST on a three-year framework for AI and digital-governance training and research and with Korea's National Information Society Agency on data governance, AI-ready datasets and digital public infrastructure, and put cumulative Korean contributions to its KOAFEC trust fund at US$132.82m as at 31 May 2026.

Two memoranda outside Seoul: the UN Economic Commission for Africa and DHL Express signed a three-year non-exclusive memorandum on 14 September to train small businesses in customs, e-commerce and digital trade, and Smart Africa's secretariat signed with a GovTech company of Ukrainian origin to build public services on its low-code platform. Neither states a budget.

The African Telecommunications Union signed a partnership with the UN Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies in July 2026 covering AI capacity building and digital public infrastructure; no text or budget is published.

New investments

Individual raises and closes: IFC took US$25m of equity inside a wider US$50m raise by Jumia on 12 August, against the investor's own projections — untested and undated — of about 60,000 annual active sellers and 1,800 direct jobs; a continental infrastructure financier and a Saudi investment company signed a combined US$300m investment in carrier-neutral platform WIOCC on 1 September, its largest capital raise to date, and the United States development finance agency's board approved US$155m of equity in the same operator on 16 September,

subject to congressional notification before commitment and closing; and a private-capital fund put US$12m into a pan-African messaging-infrastructure provider carrying one-time passwords and transaction alerts across 35 countries through 15 operator partnerships.

A women's finance programme was launched on a mobile-money rail rather than a bank one. A continental development bank and a telecommunications group launched a digital finance programme for more than 34,000 women-led enterprises in five African countries, running through the group's Mixx and Mvola platforms and combining digital lending, financial literacy training and business development services, under the bank's women's finance initiative and a multilateral facility. No tenor or disbursement schedule is published for either; the announcement puts the financing gap facing women-owned businesses on the continent at about US$49bn.

Two external programmes were measured against their own claims. The EU's Boost Africa has invested EUR108m, stated at its Abuja forum on 9 September to have attracted about EUR400m more and up to 15,000 jobs. The UK's 2024-2030 digital development strategy still carries four 2030 targets, including halving the connectivity gap in 20 countries and eight African AI labs, but an analyst finds no published funding behind it, and the Global Tech directorate line reads £24m, £22m and £24m for 2026/27 to 2028/29.

Two private vehicles were announced on 16 September: a Cape Town firm opened a R1 billion raise, reported as about US$63m, for startups and small businesses, beside an AI platform matching more than 4,000 of them to funders, with nothing yet raised; and a UK aid-funded agency is paying a consultancy to find corporate buyers for African startups, taking no stake itself.

The US development finance agency held a signing ceremony at the UN General Assembly for its board-approved equity in a pan-African digital infrastructure operator; closing is not reported.

The European Investment Bank and the European Commission confirmed the launch of Boost Ventures in Africa, a successor to Boost Africa backed by a EUR129m Commission guarantee over all its fund investments and EUR4.5m of initial technical assistance, at the Africa Venture Finance Programme in Oxford in late September; no fund commitment under it is yet published.

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